7 IONIC BONDING

We have already looked at the definition of a compound. A compound is formed when two or more elements chemically combine. In this chapter we are going to look at one way in which elements can chemically combine: by the transfer of electrons to form ionic compounds.



▲ Figure 7.1 The properties of a compound are very different from those of the elements. Sodium (an element) is a dangerously reactive metal. It is stored under oil to prevent it reacting with air or water. Chlorine (an element) is a very poisonous, reactive gas. But salt, sodium chloride (an ionic compound), is safe to eat in small quantities.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Understand how ions are formed by electron loss or gain
- Know the charges of these ions:
  - metals in Groups 1, 2 and 3
  - non-metals in Groups 5, 6 and 7
  - Ag^+, Cu^{2+}, Fe^{2+}, Fe^{3+}, Pb^{2+}, Zn^{2+}
  - hydrogen (H^+), hydroxide (OH^-), ammonium (NH_4^+), carbonate (CO_3^{2-}), nitrate (NO_3^-), sulfate (SO_4^{2-})
- Write formulae for compounds formed between the ions listed above
- Draw dot-and-cross diagrams to show the formation of ionic compounds by electron transfer, limited to combinations of elements from Groups 1, 2, 3, 5, 6 and 7 *(only outer electrons need be shown)*
- Understand ionic bonding in terms of electrostatic attractions
- Understand why compounds with giant ionic lattices have high melting and boiling points
- Know that ionic compounds do not conduct electricity when solid, but do conduct electricity when molten and in aqueous solution

IONIC BONDING

Sodium chloride is probably the best-known example of an ionic compound – one that is held together by **ionic bonding**. There are lots of other ionic compounds, such as magnesium oxide, calcium fluoride and zinc bromide. What you will realise about all these compounds is that they all contain a metal combined with a non-metal.

You can recognise ionic compounds because they (usually) contain a metal.

HINT

There are one or two exceptions to this: there are ionic compounds that do not contain a metal, for example those containing the ammonium ion (such as NH_4Cl, $(NH_4)_2SO_4$. We will look at these later.

KEY POINT

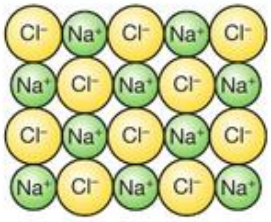
This is a simplification! In reality, you don't react sodium with chlorine atoms, but with chlorine molecules, Cl_2.

KEY POINT

You can check that sodium does have a positive charge. If you look at the Periodic Table you will see that sodium has an atomic number of 11, so it has 11 protons in its nucleus. Protons have a positive charge so the charge on the nucleus is 11+. In the sodium **atom** there are 11 electrons, each with a negative charge. These cancel out the 11+ on the nucleus and there is no overall charge. However, in the sodium ion there are only 10 electrons, so with 11+ and 10– there is an overall charge of 1+.

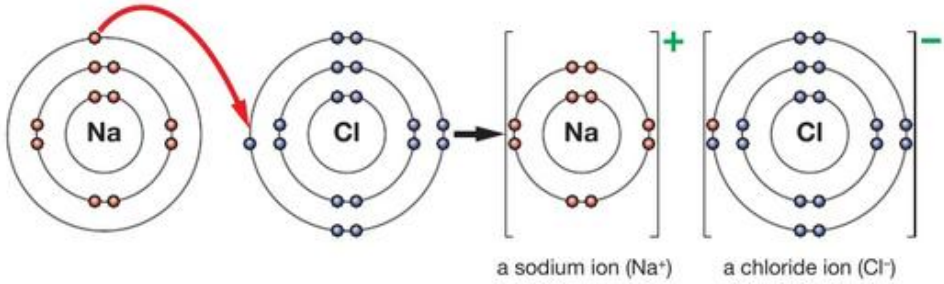
KEY POINT

Electrostatic attraction simply means that positively charged particles attract negatively charged particles.



▲ Figure 7.3 Part of the structure of a sodium chloride crystal. The structure is held together by the attraction between positive and negative ions.

When a non-metal such as chlorine combines with a metal such as sodium, the chlorine atom has a stronger attraction for electrons than the sodium atom and *an electron is transferred from the outer shell of the sodium atom to the outer shell of the chlorine atom*. Because an electron has a negative charge, when something gains an electron it becomes negatively charged, and when something loses an electron it becomes positively charged.



▲ Figure 7.2 Ionic bonding in sodium chloride. Ionic bonding involves the transfer of electron(s).

The charged particles that are formed are called **ions**.

Ions are charged particles formed when atoms (or groups of atoms) lose or gain electrons. Ions can have either a positive or a negative charge.

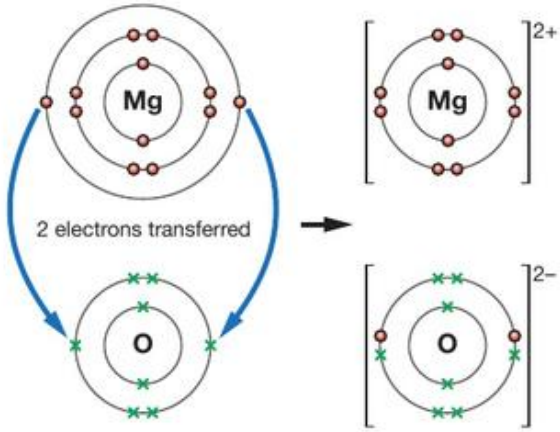
- A positive ion is called a **cation**, for example Na^+.
- A negative ion is called an **anion**, for example Cl^-.

When an ionic compound is formed, electron(s) are transferred from a metal atom to a non-metal atom to form positive and negative ions. Ionic compounds have ionic bonding. *Ionic bonding is the strong electrostatic attraction between positive and negative ions.*

Ionic bonding is often shown using **dot-and-cross diagrams**. Figure 7.4 is an example of a dot-and-cross diagram. Although the electrons are drawn as dots or as crosses, there is absolutely no difference between them in reality. The dots and the crosses simply show that the electrons have come from two different atoms. You could equally well use two different coloured dots (as in Figure 7.2), or two different coloured crosses.

IONIC BONDING IN MAGNESIUM OXIDE

A dot-and-cross diagram for MgO is shown in Figure 7.4.

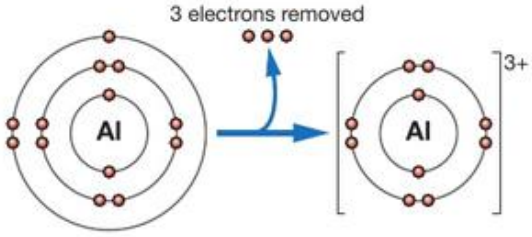


▲ Figure 7.4 A dot-and-cross diagram for magnesium oxide. When drawing these diagrams, don't forget the charges on the ions.

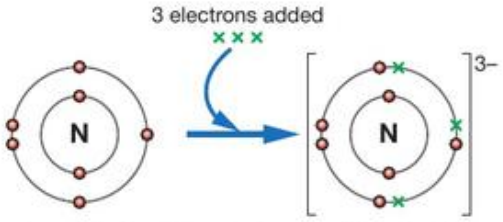
Two electrons are transferred from a magnesium atom to an oxygen atom to form Mg^{2+} and O^{2-} ions.

THE SIGNIFICANCE OF NOBLE GAS ELECTRONIC CONFIGURATIONS IN IONIC BONDING

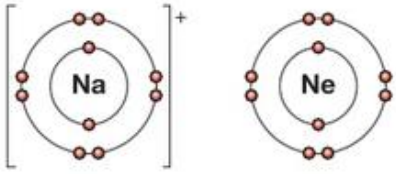
If you look at the electronic arrangements of the ions formed in Figures 7.2, 7.4, 7.5 and 7.6, each of them has a noble gas electronic configuration: [2, 8] (the same as neon) or [2, 8, 8] (the same as argon). For the first 20 elements, atoms lose or gain electrons so that they achieve a noble gas electronic configuration. The elements in Groups 1, 2 and 3 of the Periodic Table will lose their outer shell electrons to form 1+, 2+ and 3+ ions, and the elements in Groups 5, 6 and 7 will gain electrons to form 3–, 2– and 1– ions.



▲ Figure 7.5 An aluminium atom loses its 3 outer shell electrons to form an Al^{3+} ion.



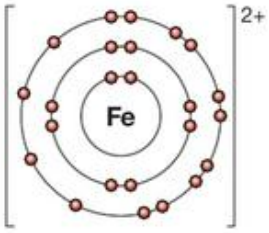
▲ Figure 7.6 A nitrogen atom gains 3 electrons to form the nitride ion (N^{3-}).



▲ Figure 7.7 Na^+ and Ne are isoelectronic – they have the same number of electrons.

KEY POINT

We sometimes use the word **isoelectronic**, which means 'have the same number of electrons'. So, when sodium forms an ion (electronic configuration [2, 8]) it becomes isoelectronic with neon [2, 8].



▲ Figure 7.8 An Fe^{2+} ion – definitely not a noble gas structure!

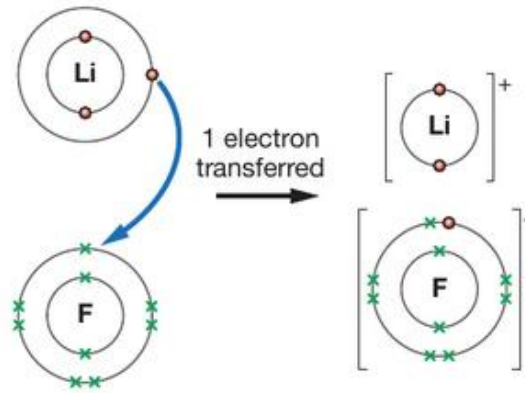
Elements in Groups 1, 2, 6 and 7 always form ions that are isoelectronic with the nearest noble gas atom. For example, rubidium (Rb), which is in Group 1, has 1 electron in its outer shell and will lose this outer shell electron to form a 1+ ion, which has the same number of electrons as a krypton (Kr) atom. Iodine is in Group 7, so it has 7 electrons in its outer shell; it will gain 1 electron when it forms an ion to form a 1– ion. This 1– ion has the same number of electrons as a xenon (Xe) atom.

However, there are a lot of common ions that don't have noble gas structures. Fe^{2+}, Fe^{3+}, Cu^{2+}, Zn^{2+}, Ag^+ and Pb^{2+} are all ions that you will come across during the International GSCE course, although you won't have to write their electronic structures. Not one of them has a noble gas structure.

OTHER EXAMPLES OF IONIC BONDING

Ionic bonds are usually formed only if small numbers of electrons need to be transferred, typically 1 or 2, but occasionally 3.

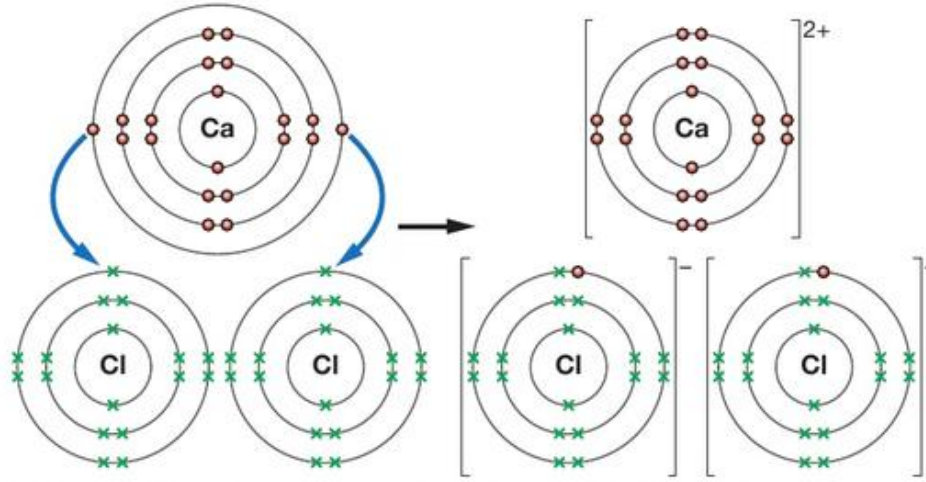
LITHIUM FLUORIDE



▲ Figure 7.9 A dot-and-cross diagram for lithium fluoride

The lithium atom has 1 electron in its outer shell that is easily lost, and the fluorine has space to receive one. One electron is transferred from the lithium atom to the fluorine atom. Lithium fluoride is held together by the strong electrostatic attractions between positive lithium (Li^+) ions and the negative fluoride (F^-) ions.

CALCIUM CHLORIDE



▲ Figure 7.10 A dot-and-cross diagram to show the formation of calcium chloride.

The calcium atom [2, 8, 8, 2] has 2 electrons in its outer shell but each chlorine atom [2, 8, 7] only has room in its outer shell to take one of them. You need two chlorines for every calcium. The 2 electrons are transferred from the outer shell of a calcium atom to two chlorine atoms, one to each. The formula for calcium chloride is therefore $CaCl_2$. There will be very strong electrostatic attractions holding the ions together because of the 2+ charge on the calcium ions.

FORMULAE FOR IONIC COMPOUNDS

There are so many different ionic compounds that you might encounter at International GSCE that it would be impossible to learn all their formulae. You need a simple way to work them out. You could work out a few from first principles, using their electronic structures, but that would take ages. Others would be too difficult. You need a simple, shortcut method.

THE NEED FOR EQUAL NUMBERS OF PLUSES AND MINUSES

Ions are formed when atoms, or groups of atoms, lose or gain electrons. They carry an electrical charge, either positive or negative. Compounds are electrically neutral. Therefore in an ionic compound there must be the right number of each sort of ion, so that the total positive charge exactly cancels out the total negative charge. Obviously, then, if you are going to work out a formula, you need to know the charges on the ions.

CASES WHERE YOU CAN WORK OUT THE CHARGE ON AN ION

Any element in Group 2 has 2 outer electrons, which it will lose to form a 2+ ion. Any element in Group 6 has 6 outer electrons, and it has room to gain 2 more; this leads to a 2– ion. Similar arguments apply in the other groups shown in Table 7.1.

Table 7.1 The charges on an ion in Groups 1–7

Group in Periodic Table	Charge on ion	Example
1	1+	Na^+
2	2+	Mg^{2+}
3	3+	Al^{3+}
5	3–	N^{3-}
6	2–	O^{2-}
7	1–	Br^-

HINT

You will always have a copy of the Periodic Table, even in an exam. That means that you can always find out which group an element is in. Elements in Group 4 only form a few ionic compounds and the situation is a bit more complicated. You will need to learn that lead forms a 2+ ion (Pb^{2+}).

REMINDER

Remember that all metals form positive ions.

CASES WHERE THE NAME TELLS YOU THE CHARGE

All metals form positive ions. Names such as lead(II) oxide, iron(III) chloride or copper(II) sulfate tell you directly about the charge on the metal ion. The number after the metal tells you the number of charges, so:

- lead(II) oxide contains a Pb^{2+} ion
- iron(III) chloride contains an Fe^{3+} ion
- copper(II) sulfate contains a Cu^{2+} ion.

You cannot work out the charges for some ions, you have to learn them. Ions that need to be learned are shown in Table 7.2.

Table 7.2 Ions that you should learn.

Charge	Substance	Ion	Charge	Substance	Ion
positive	zinc	Zn^{2+}	negative	nitrate	NO_3^-
	silver	Ag^+		hydroxide	OH^-
	hydrogen	H^+		carbonate	CO_3^{2-}
	ammonium	NH_4^+		sulfate	SO_4^{2-}

KEY POINT

Ammonium chloride (NH_4Cl) is an example of an ionic compound that does not contain a metal. There is ionic bonding between the NH_4^+ and Cl^- ions. There is, however, also covalent bonding (see Chapter 8) in this compound: the NH_4^+ ion is held together by covalent bonding.

You will encounter other ions during the course, but these are the important ones for now. The ions in this list are the difficult ones – be sure to learn both the formula and the charge for each ion.

CONFUSING ENDINGS!

Don't confuse ions such as sulf**ate** and sulf**ide**. A name like copper(II) sulf**ide** means that it contains copper and sulfur **only**. Any '**ide**' ending means that there isn't anything complicated there. Sodium chloride, for example, is just sodium and chlorine combined together. So copper(II) sulfide contains Cu^{2+} and S^{2-} ions.



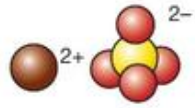
copper(II) sulfide

▲ Figure 7.11 Copper(II) sulfide is CuS.

HINT

Not looking carefully at word endings is one of the most common mistakes students make when they start to write formulae. Be careful!

Once you have an '**ate**' ending, it means that there is oxygen (and possibly other things) there as well. So, for example, copper(II) sulfate contains copper, sulfur and oxygen.



copper(II) sulfate

▲ Figure 7.12 Copper(II) sulfate is $CuSO_4$.

DEDUCING THE FORMULA FOR AN IONIC COMPOUND

EXAMPLE 1

To find the formula for sodium oxide

Sodium is in Group 1, so the ion is Na^+.

Oxygen is in Group 6, so the ion is O^{2-}.

To have equal numbers of positive and negative charges, you would need two sodium ions to provide the two positive charges to cancel the two negative charges on one oxide ion. In other words, you need:

Na^+ Na^+ O^{2-}

The formula is therefore **Na_2O**.

EXAMPLE 2

To find the formula for barium nitrate

Barium is in Group 2, so the ion is Ba^{2+}.

Nitrate ions are NO_3^-. You will have to remember this.

To have equal numbers of positive and negative charges, you would need two nitrate ions for each barium ion.

The formula is **$Ba(NO_3)_2$**.

Notice the brackets around the nitrate group. *Brackets must be written if you have more than one of these complex ions* (ions containing more than one atom). In any other situation, they are completely unnecessary.

KEY POINT

If you didn't write the brackets, the formula would look like this: $BaNO_{32}$. That would read as 1 barium, 1 nitrogen and 32 oxygens!

EXAMPLE 3

To find the formula for iron(III) sulfate

Iron(III) tells you that the metal ion is Fe^{3+}.

Sulfate ions are SO_4^{2-}.

To have equal numbers of positive and negative charges, you would need two iron(III) ions for every three sulfate ions, giving 6+ and 6– in total.

The formula is $\mathbf{Fe_2(SO_4)_3}$.

A shortcut to working out complicated formulae such as these is to just swap over the numbers in the charges. This is shown in Figure 7.13.



▲ Figure 7.13 If you cross over the numbers in the charges you will get the formula.

CALCIUM CHLORIDE PROVIDES ANOTHER EXAMPLE

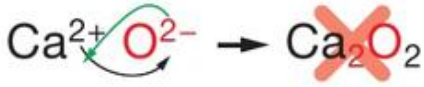


▲ Figure 7.14 To work out the formula of calcium chloride we cross over the numbers in the charges. There is no extra number in front of the charge in Cl^- because we do not tend to write in a 1.

KEY POINT

Why aren't ion charges shown in formulae? Actually, they can be shown. For example, the formula for sodium chloride is NaCl. It is sometimes written Na^+Cl^- if you are trying to make a particular point, but for most purposes the charges are left out. In an ionic compound, the charges are there, whether you write them or not.

You have to be careful using this method because you can get the wrong answer when the charges on the ions are the same. For example, the formula of calcium oxide is CaO and not Ca_2O_2. When the charges on the positive and negative ions are the same you can deduce that there will be 1 of each ion in the formula, so there is no need to swap anything over.



▲ Figure 7.15 The formula of calcium oxide is CaO and not Ca_2O_2.

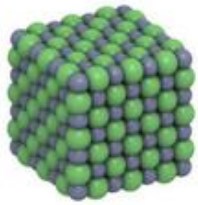
GIANT IONIC STRUCTURES

All ionic compounds form crystals that consist of lattices of positive and negative ions packed together in a regular way. A **lattice** is a regular array of particles. The lattice is held together by the strong electrostatic attractions between the positively and negatively charged ions.



▲ Figure 7.16 A lattice fence. A lattice is a regular, repeating structure.

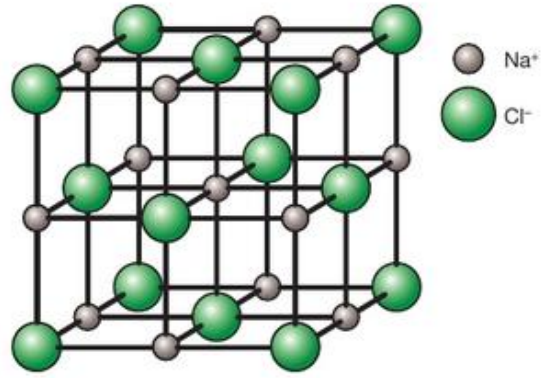
THE STRUCTURE OF SODIUM CHLORIDE



▲ Figure 7.17 A model of a small part of a sodium chloride crystal

Figure 7.17 shows how the ions in a crystal of sodium chloride are arranged.

In diagrams, the ions are usually drawn in an 'exploded' view (Figure 7.18). Each sodium ion is surrounded by 6 chloride ions. In turn, each chloride ion is surrounded by 6 sodium ions. You have to remember that this pattern repeats itself throughout the structure over vast numbers of ions.



▲ Figure 7.18 An 'exploded' view of sodium chloride. The lines in this diagram are not bonds, they are just there to help show the arrangement of the ions. Those ions joined by lines are touching each other.

The structure of sodium chloride is described as a **giant ionic lattice**. We are using the word '**giant**' here not in the sense of big but rather to describe a structure where there are no individual molecules. All the sodium ions in the structure attract all the chloride ions, we cannot pick out sodium chloride molecules; there are no individual molecules. The bonding in a giant ionic lattice extends throughout the structure in all directions. There is no limit to the number of particles present, all we know is that there must be the same number of sodium and chloride ions.

HINT

This is really important: you must not talk about *molecules* of an ionic compound. This will be marked wrong in the exam and you could lose all the marks for a question!

THE STRUCTURE OF MAGNESIUM OXIDE

Magnesium oxide, MgO, contains magnesium ions, Mg^{2+}, and oxide ions, O^{2-}. It has exactly the same structure as sodium chloride. The only difference is that the magnesium oxide lattice is held together by stronger forces of attraction. This is because in magnesium oxide, 2+ ions are attracting 2– ions. In sodium chloride, the electrostatic attractions are weaker because they are only between 1+ and 1– ions.

EXTENSION WORK

The Mg^{2+} ion is also smaller than the Na^+ ion, and the O^{2-} ion is smaller than the Cl^- ion. This causes stronger attractions but the effect of the charge on the ions is more important.



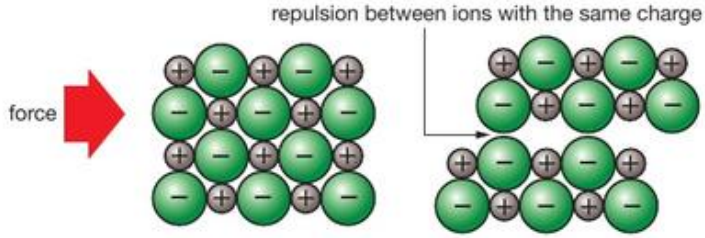
▲ Figure 7.19 Sodium chloride is crystalline

THE PHYSICAL PROPERTIES OF IONIC SUBSTANCES

Ionic compounds have high melting points and boiling points because of the strong electrostatic forces of attraction holding the lattice together. A lot of energy has to be supplied to break the strong electrostatic forces of attraction between oppositely charged ions in the giant lattice structure.

Ionic compounds tend to be crystalline. This reflects the regular arrangement of ions in the lattice. Sometimes the crystals are too small to be seen except under powerful microscopes. Magnesium oxide, for example, is always seen as a white powder because the individual crystals are too small to be seen with the naked eye.

Ionic crystals tend to be brittle. This is because any small distortion of a crystal will bring ions with the same charge alongside each other. Like charges repel and so the crystal splits itself apart.



▲ Figure 7.20 Ionic crystals tend to be brittle

KEY POINT

Organic solvents include ethanol (alcohol) and hydrocarbons, such as hexane and those found in petrol. If you are interested in these, you could explore the organic chemistry section of this book (Unit 4).

Ionic substances tend to be soluble in water.

Ionic compounds tend to be insoluble in organic solvents.

EXTENSION WORK

The reasons that ionic compounds tend to be soluble in water are quite complicated. Water is a covalent molecule (Chapter 8) but the electrons in the bonds are more attracted towards the oxygen end of the bond. This makes the oxygen slightly negative and the hydrogen slightly positive – the molecule is called **polar**. This means that reasonably strong forces can be formed between water molecules and ions, which provide the energy to break the lattice apart.

Not all ionic substances are soluble in water: magnesium oxide isn't soluble in water because the attractions between the water molecules and the ions aren't strong enough to overcome the very strong electrostatic forces of attraction between magnesium and oxide ions.

Hexane is non-polar and does not form strong enough attractions to the ions to break apart the ionic lattice.

THE ELECTRICAL CONDUCTIVITY OF IONIC SUBSTANCES

HINT

Molten just means that the salt has been melted – it is a liquid.

Ionic compounds don't conduct electricity when they are solid because the *ions* are fixed in position and are not free to move around. They do, however, conduct electricity when they are **molten** (have melted) or if they are dissolved in water (in aqueous solution). This happens because the *ions* then become free to move around. It is really important that you use the correct words when explaining this. Do not use the word 'electrons'. You must talk about the **ions** being free to move.

CHAPTER QUESTIONS

SKILLS INTERPRETATION 7

SKILLS CRITICAL THINKING 8

1 a Explain what is meant by i an ion and ii ionic bonding.

b In each of the following cases, write down the electronic configurations of the original atoms and then explain (in words or diagrams) what happens when:

i sodium bonds with chlorine to make sodium chloride

ii lithium bonds with oxygen to make lithium oxide

iii magnesium bonds with fluorine to make magnesium fluoride.

SKILLS INTERPRETATION

2 Draw dot-and-cross diagrams to show the ions formed (outer electrons only) when:

a potassium combines with fluorine

b calcium combines with bromine

c magnesium combines with iodine.